

Public Questions and Mayor's Responses

West of England Combined Authority Committee and West of England Joint Committee

Friday 27 March 2026

Question 1 – Mary Collett

Any potential reductions in emissions and improvements in air quality linked with a mass transit scheme would be entirely wiped out if a mass transit scheme to Bristol Airport was linked with approval for expansion to 15mppa.

Can WECA assure residents that any potential contribution made by Bristol Airport towards the cost of a possible mass transit scheme won't be linked to the potential use of political influence to help make Bristol Airport's 15mppa planning application happen.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

In July, I set out my position in relation to the airport, explaining that new laws tabled in Parliament look set to provide regional mayors with new powers on planning. For our part of the world, that would include North Somerset should they join our combined authority. Mindful of that responsibility, my approach, now and in the future, will be to carefully consider planning applications at the appropriate stage, looking at all the evidence.

Last month, we published our Transport Vision and this sets out our ambitions for a transport network that people can trust. We have a record transport funding settlement of £752 million secured last year from government, and around £150 million is proposed to be allocated to developing mass transit. Council leaders and I have a shared ambition to begin delivering the first mass transit projects within

four to five years. We see high-quality mass transit as being an essential ingredient to connecting up our Growth Zones across the region, one of which is the North Somerset Growth Gateway (which includes the airport).

We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

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Question 2 – CJ Lamb

Do you see it as the role of the mayoral combined authority under its strategic spatial planning remit to facilitate the co-operative working, required by the 2011 Localism Act, between the neighbouring local planning authorities over identifying transit or 'meanwhile sites' for homeless travellers so that Bristol, with shortage of land space and a far bigger population than the rest, does not bear the brunt of providing sites for the over 600 van dwellers within the city boundaries. Not only do neighbouring unitary authorities have smaller populations, they also have larger land masses to accommodate pitches.

Mayor's Response:

The SDS is set to cover Bath & North East Somerset, Bristol, North Somerset, and South Gloucestershire, as we work together to build the right homes in the right places, with the services and infrastructure that communities need.

Emerging national planning policy (the Draft National Planning Policy Framework 2025), under which the Spatial Development Strategy (SDS) will be prepared, states that a SDS should assess “the permanent and transit site accommodation needs of travellers in the area.” As the Strategy develops, we are commissioning

evidence to further understand the breakdown of accommodation needs across the region, and we'll publish that in due course.

Question 3 – CJ Lamb

What are the plans during this parliament to approach the government for further funding for the WE(MCA) transport 'vision', and is further funding feasible given the £45 billion government funding already committed to Northern Powerhouse Rail, £2 billion for a new railway station in Bradford, £1 billion for a new tram link in Birmingham and £14 billion for railways in Wales. Isn't the truth that WE(MCA) is well behind the loop in terms of clout with government?

Mayor's Response:

In this new chapter, we are banging the drum for our region. The West's voice is finally starting to be heard, as we work to catch up with other regions and make the most of devolution.

Through the Transport for City Regions (TCR) programme, we have secured £752 million in further funding to invest by 2032. We have developed a Local Transport Delivery Plan, which has been submitted to the Department for Transport (DfT), which sets out a high-level allocation of £150 million for rail projects and the significant development of our rail programme. It is our intention to use this opportunity to develop our growing rail network and continue to make the case to government for additional funding in future spending rounds.

We are having productive conversations with DfT and other departments, and our Transport Vision last month was welcomed by the Secretary of State for Transport as well as business and transport leaders across our region and beyond.

Question 4 – Councillor Rob Bryher

The Mayor recently attended the closing event of Playing Out at City Hall and expressed disappointment that more School Streets are not being rolled out by Bristol City Council. I share her frustration to some extent, but I would note that liveable neighbourhoods schemes and modal filters more generally can deliver a lot of the

benefits of School Streets with the added benefit that they usually cover a much larger area of a neighbourhood than just the 100 metres or so outside of a school. This has huge potential benefit for children in terms of reducing road danger, air pollution and other barriers to being able to walk, wheel, scoot and cycle to school.

Does the Mayor agree with me that we should rename low-traffic neighbourhoods and liveable neighbourhoods as School Safe Travel Areas or Child Safe Travel Areas so that it is clear to the public and politicians what the aim of these schemes really is?

Mayor's Response:

I've long been supportive of School Streets, having started the programme in Bristol while I was a councillor. We've secured more funding for active travel, and our Transport Vision sets out an ambition to double the number of School Streets around our region.

As you'll know, we have commissioned an independent review of the East Bristol Liveable Neighbourhood trial, considering all of the data. This is intended as a comprehensive evaluation to inform future decision making, rather than a rebranding exercise.

Question 5 – Councillor Rob Bryher

What is the current estimated cost to taxpayers of the independent review of the East Bristol Liveable Neighbourhood trial scheme?

Mayor's Response:

Once the independent review has been completed in the spring, we will share the final costs when confirmed.

Question 6 – Jackie Pyrah

WECA states it is 'committed to tackling the climate and ecological emergency by becoming a net zero carbon region and halting the decline of the natural environment by 2030'. Does this mean WECA will not be supporting any Airport Expansion until:-

1. There is a Mass transit system in place that is proven to reduce traffic to and from the airport.
2. That the airport withdraws all plans to acquire Felton Common Land, a designated local nature reserve and site of nature conservation, featuring species-rich grassland, rare waxcap fungi, and habitats for bats and declining bird species.

NB. I realise that the Airport is not in the WECA region, but the cumulative effects of its constant bid to expand has an adverse effect on those of us who do live in the WECA region, and are subject to the fall out from its operations.

Mayor's Response:

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We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The

first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

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Question 7 – Hilary Burn

Bristol Airport is submitting an application for expansion to 15 mppa imminently. The mass transit to the Airport is not yet secure. Can you please inform me of the route of the Mass Transit and when a local consultation will be held on the route for residents to be to give their views. Will the Mass Transit be delivered before 2035? How much has been allocated for the Mass Transit.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 8 – Emily Arnold

What is the proposed route of the mass transport link from Bristol to the airport, and what impact will it have on the environment?

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Question 9 – Emily Arnold

Will such a scheme be able to cope with the current number of passengers trying to get to the airport, let alone the extra 3 million they are proposing to apply for?

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Question 10 - Sam Carrier

, I am concerned about proposals for a mass transit scheme that will affect North Somerset when there are serious flaws and a number of unanswered questions. I would like to ask the following two questions:

Question 1:

Is there an agreed budget for the scheme including where the money is coming from?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 11 - Sam Carrier

, I am concerned about proposals for a mass transit scheme that will affect North Somerset when there are serious flaws and a number of unanswered questions. I would like to ask the following two questions:

Question 2:

Have North Somerset agreed/been party to proposals affecting North Somerset

Mayor's Response:

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Question 12 – Christine Jones

1) where is the proposed location for this mass transit scheme?

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Question 13 – Christine Jones

how is this scheme going to be financed?

As a resident of Felton I am already concerned about the proposed increase I'm in airport traffic and the effect on Felton Village.

There are currently no traffic calming measures and many of the airport passengers drive through Felton as if they are in a car rally. This makes it almost impossible for the horse riders to ride out particularly on a Wednesday and Friday afternoon.

The vehicles also continue to hack up the lay-bys on the A38 leaving their rubbish, including dirty nappies, urine filled plastic bottles, discarded take away cartoons and bottles or cans of any description. I have first hand experience of this as I regularly go out as a volunteer litter picker.

There continues to be no signage of the A38 stating "heavy traffic ignore Sat Nav and

stay on the A38” their journeys will not be shorter as they will queue in Currells Lane, Newditch Lane or West Lane only to find themselves back on the A38.

The airport will likely endorse the mass transit scheme and use this as a reason to apply for increased passenger numbers. The airport expansion plans using this strategy should be denied until such time as the transit scheme is in place.

With regard to the transit scheme depending on the route if they propose to use the A38 there will always be a bottleneck by the tanks as these are a permanent fixture.

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Question 14 – Charlie Siret

In her recent comments to the Bristol Post, the Mayor implied that franchising is too expensive for the residents of the West of England. This assumes that a precept would be a greater cost to the average resident than the current circumstances; however, recent research from the University of Bristol found that "the silent cost of [Bristol's] selective transport system is already being paid by those least able to bear it." This supports those we have spoken to in the West of England, who have told us that there is a high financial cost of the unreliability and poor service provision of buses, as they are missing out on job opportunities, healthcare, leisure, social support, and education, or paying for petrol or using taxis to get there.

As the main reason given for rejecting franchising is a core assumption that a precept for franchising would be more expensive to the average West of England resident than improved bus services and infrastructure, can the Authority provide evidence to support this claim?

Mayor's Response:

We are committed to reforming our buses and improving services for passengers.

We are looking carefully at all of the options for how to take greater control of our buses, with several different operating/funding models on the table. Franchising is not a quick or cheap fix. It takes years and has meant an extra charge on people's council tax bills elsewhere - which is not something we want to rush into. It's true that what's right for somewhere else may not always be the best model for the West of England, which is much more rural than other places, including Greater Manchester, and so we're looking to make the right choice for us.

More immediately, we're already working to quickly improve our bus network, as we secure more investment and make the most of devolution to catch up with

other regions. Over 250 new green buses will be on our streets by the end of this year, with four electric depots, alongside offers like Kids Go Free over the school holidays – including this Easter. In the coming weeks, we will be asking people to have their say more generally on our buses to help shape our developing Bus Plan as part of a transport network that people can trust.

Question 15 – Julie Main

As Bristol Airport are putting in planning to expand their number of passengers, to extend the runway and to move their landing lights, much of the justification and publicity has been over a new mass transit scheme as the overall highways have not been fit for purpose with the current passenger numbers and the existing agreement to extend those numbers. Therefore my questions are, why not wait until the scheme is completed before any airport expansion plans are considered and supported?

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Question 16 – Julie Main

secondly, what is the intended route, bearing in my mind that the A38 would not support any extension to lane sizes due to properties alongside and the reservoirs themselves

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Question 17 - Katherine Martin

As a resident of South Gloucestershire I am concerned about the recent conversations around a mass transport scheme to Bristol Airport.

This seems like a complete fantasy which will be a huge waste of public money, I am interested in having answers to two questions:

1. What work has been undertaken to assess the feasibility of the scheme? This includes what will the costs be, is there money available to cover the costs of the scheme, its practicality given the geographical constraints along the A38

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 18 - Katherine Martin

2. Bristol airport's is currently consuklting on expanding the airport without firm plans to improve the transport infrastructure, while I understand WECA have no say in planning decisions would they reccomend expansion plans are put on hold until the transport infrastructure is improved.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 19 – Denise Cutlan

I object to the Bristol airport plan to use the mass transit scheme to justify a huge increase in passengers some 3 million.

My Questions:

1. The roads and lanes around the airport area are very narrow, often single track. Already very busy.

What route for the mass transit scheme is planned between the lakes/ reservoirs and would this route be safe for road users and pedestrians?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 20 – Denise Cutlan

2. What is the cost of the scheme and how will the mass transit scheme be funded?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 21 – Martin Cutlan

I am concerned that Bristol Airport is using the mass transit scheme as a means of increasing passenger numbers and further expansion.

My questions:

1. When is the mass transit scheme be completed?

Mayor's Response:

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linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 22 – Martin Cutlan

2. Why would the airport expansion plans be considered before the transit scheme is completed? Surely the expansion plans decision should be put on hold until the

completion of the scheme.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 23 – Tricia Woodhead

As a long term resident of Dundry Village in North Somerset I am asking two questions on the matter of any proposed MASS TRANSIT system and it's extension into North Somerset in the vicinity or parallel to the A38 corridor.

Questions

1) What consultation is in hand for residents of North Somerset who will be negatively impacted during construction of any such project without any obvious benefit in the medium or long term unless their needs are considered in the planning phase?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 24 – Tricia Woodhead

Where is the money coming from the pay for this when all local authorities have budgets under pressure and have increased council taxes by 5-8% without taking on any new projects of this scope and size?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 25 – Laura Jury

My questions for the proposed mass transport scheme:

1) Will Bristol Airport be contributing significantly more funds to the proposed mass transport scheme, given their application for Felton Common would mean significantly larger planes and therefore significantly higher revenues?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 26 – Laura Jury

2) How will the mass transport scheme be developed to improve the transport facilities for both local residents and Bristol Airport, given the airport plan to increase the number of visitors significantly?

Bristol Airports application to build lights onto Felton Common is a disgrace. The local community is strong and will block this at every path. We will not lay down and simply allow this to happen. We are up for the fight.

Mayor's Response:

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project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 27 – Maureen Hutchison

I would like to submit two questions and a statement regarding Bristol Airport's proposed mass transport scheme in relation to its proposed expansion.

(1) What route have they proposed to take from central Bristol, given that the present A38 is congested already, has buildings on both sides at many points and would be particularly difficult at the pinch point between the reservoirs?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 28 – Maureen Hutchison

(2) Have Bristol Airport submitted costings for the mass transport scheme they are proposing?

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Question 29 – Melanie Patch Winford

Proposed Mass transit scheme

Could you inform me where and when the reality of this route of this proposed scheme from Bristol will take ?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 30 – Melanie Patch Winford

and what sort of budget there is for it ?

I am concerned that our existing road network doesn't really offer any capacity to expand to accommodate this idea

Mayor's Response:

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Question 31 – Ben Moss

Aware of WECA meeting next week, I'd like to put two questions towards the body. The questions relate to the proposed Mass Transit (MT) scheme and how it may or relate to Bristol Airport Limited's (BAL) expansion plans. My suspicion is that the MT will be used as an excuse to support BAL's expansion plans and vice versa.

My two questions are as follows:

1) There is already an under-utilised (due to it's expensive cost) 24hr coach service that runs to the airport from Bristol centre (the Bristol Flyer / A1). How will the Mass Transit system overcome the real physical constraints of the Barrow Gurney reservoirs , which in effect enforce single-lane traffic in either direction, that the already existing coach service encounters?

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 32 – Ben Moss

It's well understood that a Mass Transit Scheme will take many, many years to complete. Why not wait until this is complete before giving Bristol Airport permission, (or support of the application for permission) to expand beyond the current 12mppa they have permission for, rather than their desired 15mppa?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 33 – Adam Thompson

The impact on the local villages around the airport is huge. Issues including cars parking outside our entrances then ordering Uber to airport, cars waiting to collect and then littering the roads, cars waiting to collect and using local lanes to use the toilet and I don't mean just to pee. The traffic impact is incredible. There is no way the airport should expand until there are massively improved traffic links. This should be rail and dual carriageway.

Questions

Will the improved traffic links all have to be completed before the airport can accept more people.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 34 – Adam Thompson

What is the budget for traffic improvement ? If it's not into billions which is what it will need for road and rail , it will not have any impact and be a waste of time and money.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 35 – Roger Lowrey

How does the WECA strategy align with page 6 of this .

[Link Removed]

which say we will only have three major airports

Ukfires.org appear to be the main advisors to the government. So why is Bristol Airport being allowed to expand

Mayor's Response:

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Question 36 – Roger Lowrey

What definite projects are in place, to deal with the mass public transport, Bristol Airport will require for its immediate expansion plans ?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 37 – Ozzy Osborne

How can BA possibly be granted this extra 3 million on the basis of a mass transit scheme that has no clear plan, no costing and for which there is no budget.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 38 – Ozzy Osborne

If in the unlikely event funding is found for this deeply unpopular scheme how would a route be found to navigate between the two reservoirs at Barrow?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 39 – Mike Ephgrave

It appears the main beneficiary of the Mass Transit Scheme (MTS) is Bristol airport. What is the cost of the scheme and what proportion of those costs stem being met by Bristol Airport?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 40 – Mike Ephgrave

If the MTS is supposed to have positive environmental benefits wouldn't it be more beneficial to the west of England to curtail the use or close Bristol Airport completely? This would have a massive positive effect on the carbon footprint of the area.⁷

Mayor's Response:

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Question 41 – Neil Davidge

I am a neighbour to Bristol Airport in the village of Felton and we daily have to deal with the noise, the pollution and increasingly dangerous traffic problems. I am also a parent and recently a grandparent and care deeply about the state of the world we are handing to our children and grandchildren. The latest plan of Bristol Airport to acquire half of Felton common is nothing short of rampant profiteering going against the interests of the general public and would be a very dangerous precedent if granted, it's proof, if it was ever needed, of how little they actually care about the region.

We believe Bristol Airport are planning to use the mass transit scheme to try to justify adding 3 million extra passengers a year but this would seem presumptuous considering no one yet knows what form or even if it is possible to create a mass transit corridor between Bristol city and the airport. Would it not be better to wait for the scheme to be completed before considering Bristol Airports plans?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 42 – Neil Davidge

Do any of the voting members of WECA have a personal interest in Bristol Airport being permitted to increase the number of flights by 3 million per year?

Mayor's Response:

Members' registers of interests can be found on the combined authority's website.

Question 43 - Mrs KC Martin

I understand that WECA are proposing a Mass transit system for Bristol Airport and believe as a resident of North Somerset (Winford village) I am entitled to ask 2 Questions about the proposed Transit system.

As the Councils involved have no money how is this going to be funded and what proportion of the money will be used to help the villages affected by traffic coming from the East through Chew Magna, Winford and Felton?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 44 - Mrs KC Martin

How is the proposed route going to overcome the problem of the narrow part of the A38 at Barrow Tanks and in planning the route what how will it affect the junction at Barrow Lane for residents of Winford trying to join the A38 heading into Bristol?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 45 – Simon Martin

Hi I have the misfortune to live on the B3130 in Winford where our lives are daily blighted by heavy traffic from the East going to Bristol Airport. BA is currently at approx 10.5 MPA with existing permission to increase to 12 MPA the roads can already not cope and if anything happens on the M5 or A38 our village is gridlocked as people use small side roads to try and get round. BA now want to put landing lights on Felton Common to get to 15MPA and we expect they will use the proposed Mass Transit System as part of their submission.

As this appears to be in the very early stages of planning I understand I am able to ask 2 questions.

Has a fully budgeted proposal for a Mass Transit System including Bristol Airport been produced yet?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 46 – Simon Martin

Have Bristol Airport had any input or discussions with WECA about a Mass Transit System that includes the Airport.

As I expect we will shortly be in WECA as a concerned citizen BA should not be able to include aspect of a possible future MTS in any application to increase to 15 MPA.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

In July, I set out my position in relation to the airport, explaining that new laws tabled in Parliament look set to provide regional mayors with new powers on planning. For our part of the world, that would include North Somerset should they join our combined authority. Mindful of that responsibility, my approach, now and in the future, will be to carefully consider planning applications at the appropriate stage, looking at all the evidence.

Last month, we published our Transport Vision and this sets out our ambitions for a transport network that people can trust. We have a record transport funding settlement of £752 million secured last year from government, and around £150 million is proposed to be allocated to developing mass transit. Council leaders and I have a shared ambition to begin delivering the first mass transit projects within four to five years. We see high-quality mass transit as being an essential ingredient to connecting up our Growth Zones across the region, one of which is the North Somerset Growth Gateway (which includes the airport).

We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 47 – Janet Teggin

Hi, I have read your West of England Transport Vision, which sets out your aspirations but I would like to know:

- When will you publish a fully costed set of technical proposals to deliver actual solutions in terms of routes and mode of transport backed up with a management plan?

Mayor's Response:

The Transport Vision is intentionally a high-level document, which sets out our shared ambition to build a transport network that people can trust – including better buses, more trains, mass transit plans, active travel, and much more.

We are now developing our Transport Strategy, which will give more technical details on the specific schemes and an outline delivery programme for the Transport for City Regions (TCR) programme. Today's committee papers including draft allocations for this programme, and set out that the Transport Strategy is anticipated to be published at the end of the year.

Question 48 – Janet Teggin

- When will the people of North Somerset be consulted about actual proposed solutions?

Your vision document is simply a wish-list, it does not address the reality of delivering your vision and presumably the destruction of landscape, which would be required to be swept away to make it happen. Your vision document makes countless statements of so-called facts but does not back them up with any references collaborating source. To quote just a few: Page 12 - "Looking ahead forecasts suggest car use could increase by 30% over 20 years"; page 28 - "Regional rail use has increased by 130% since 2000"; page 30 - "Only 50% of the region's population can access a major centre within 30 minutes by public transport". To be credible statements the sources need to be referenced. The mass transit systems, which operate in other parts of the world did not happen without removing what was previously in their place, you fail to highlight that. No doubt in some cities in Europe, WWII had done the levelling for them.

Mayor's Response:

The Transport Vision is intentionally a high-level document, which sets out our shared ambition to build a transport network that people can trust – including better buses, more trains, mass transit plans, active travel, and much more.

We are now developing our Transport Strategy, which will give more technical details on the specific schemes and an outline delivery programme for the Transport for City Regions (TCR) programme.

All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on transport proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring projects forward. Public consultation will also take place as these develop.

Question 49 - Justin Milward

1. Please can you provide an update on the current possible route(s) of the Proposed Mass Transit Scheme ?

Mayor's Response:

The Transport Vision is intentionally a high-level document, which sets out our shared ambition to build a transport network that people can trust – including better buses, more trains, mass transit plans, active travel, and much more.

We are now developing our Transport Strategy, which will give more technical details on potential routes, as well as other specific schemes and an outline delivery programme for the Transport for City Regions (TCR) plan.

Question 50 - Justin Milward

2. Is there a provisional timescale for implementation of the Proposed Mass Transit Scheme ?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

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We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 51 – Nigel Bailey

1. is there any money set aside for a proposed mass transit scheme from Bristol to Bristol Airport.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 52 – Nigel Bailey

2.if so what is the timescale until it's running.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 53 – Nicola Bailey

1.Are the any plans for a mass transit scheme for improving surface access to Bristol airport

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning

applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 54 – Nicola Bailey

2.Are there any funds set aside for such a scheme

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not

linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 55 – Keith Pletts

Bristol Airport is situated in North Somerset and in addition, claims to be the regional airport for Cornwall, Devon, South Wales, Gloucestershire, Wiltshire, Dorset and Hampshire.

Many of these counties have their own local airports with capacity to expand and offer easier access for local passengers. Airports at Exeter, Cardiff, Bournemouth and Gloucester spring to mind. There is no necessity to expand Bristol Airport.

I live in Regil, a parish within the Felton responsibility for local matters and owners of Felton Common. I would like to submit two questions.

Question 1 - The airport is sited to the south of Bristol and is some distance from all motorway exits, through and around Bristol. To relieve the traffic in Bristol and surrounding areas coming to Bristol Airport from South Wales, Gloucestershire, Wiltshire, Devon, Cornwall there is a need for a spur road to the airport from the Clevedon exit on the M5. There is insufficient capacity for thousands more vehicles accessing the airport through Bristol and surrounding areas

Mayor's Response:

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Question 56 – Keith Pletts

Question 2 - Is Bristol Airport liable for the costs for the construction of a link road or indeed other schemes to alleviate the inevitable chaos caused that will occur due to the airport expansion? If Bristol airport are not liable to fund the expansion of any infrastructure relating or required specifically for the airport expansion, who is?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 57 – Roger Gimson

Bristol Walking Alliance has the following two questions to put to the Combined Authority at its meeting on 27 March 2026:

Looking at the broad allocation of Transforming City Regions funding in the Transport paper, it is difficult to tell what has been allocated to measures that make the environment for walking safer and more welcoming.

In particular:

- £50m for Active Travel, ie £10m pa, is clear but much of that could be for cycle routes, similarly the £2m allocated for Active Travel scheme development in the next two years.
- CRSTS had £20m for Liveable Neighbourhoods, which are a major benefit for walking, especially for children and their parents. The TCR allocations have nothing.

- CRSTS had Strategic Corridors £334m. TCR's closest equivalent is Bus £150m. Strategic corridors have brought some improvements for walking, eg improved crossings, wider footways, and continuous footways across side junctions. Will spending under the heading 'Bus' also introduce some improvements for walking?

To what extent will the TCR allocation of £752m specifically benefit walking?

Mayor's Response:

The current draft plan for Transport for City Regions (TCR) funding includes broad allocations for different modes of transport, including £50 million for active travel improvements which will make a big difference for safer walking, wheeling, and cycling routes. We have also recently secured £12 million from Active Travel England to invest over the coming years, in line with our commitment to active travel in the Transport Vision.

In the coming months we are working closely with the Department for Transport on a more detailed delivery plan which will be submitted later this year, ahead of the start of the TCR funding window.

We are working with our partners on the evidence base for where funding can best be allocated to make the most difference and support the West of England Growth Strategy.

Question 58 – Roger Gimson

One of the worst pedestrian routes in Bristol is along the A4 between Temple Meads Station and Three Lamps Junction. The footway is shared with cyclists, despite being only 2m wide, and is immediately adjacent to passing vehicles on a very busy road.

To address this problem, we understand new walking/cycling bridges will be necessary across the Avon New Cut and across the two sets of railway lines.

Will the TCR fund be used to cover the implementation of these bridges and associated works?

Mayor's Response:

The current draft plan for Transport for City Regions (TCR) funding includes broad allocations for different modes of transport, and follows on from regionally-funded bridge repairs along the New Cut over recent years.

In the coming months we are working closely with the Department for Transport on a more detailed delivery plan which will be submitted later this year, ahead of the start of the TCR funding window. We are working with our partners on the evidence base for where funding can best be allocated to make the most difference and support the West of England Growth Strategy.

Question 59 – David Redgewell

With First group plc Greater Western trains company limited GWR.

Applying to run the Bristol Temple meads station to Oxford service via Bath spa, Chippenham and Swindon as a local inter city Express trains service but with office of Road and Rail

Not yet grant a licence permission to run the Services,

As this service is supported in Principle by Bristol city council, Banes, Wiltshire Council, Swindon Borough Council and Oxfordshire and Oxford council.

Western Gateway Transport Board

What progress and discussion have the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and mayor Helen Goodwin, had with the Office of road and to make sure this service has necessary Office of Road and Rail clearance to Run the service from may 2026 .

This needs west of England mayoral combined transport Authority urgently discussion with ORR.

We do not want the same situation

as 07 00 Manchester piccadilly to London Euston refused by ORR the Reinstated because of the North mayor's pressure

Also have discussion taken place on

First Group plc lumo ,

Paignton, Torquay, Torre, Newton Abbot, Teignmouth Dawish Exeter St Davids Taunton, Bridgwater Highbridge Nalisea Yatton for clevedon Nalisea and Backwell Parson street, Bristol Bath spa, Chippenham, Swindon London Paddington,

and the co op rail company Bishop Lydeard Railway station Taunton, Bridgwater Highbridge and Burnham on sea weston super mare.

Taunton, castle cary for Yeovil Bruton Frome Westbury Trowbridge Melksham
chippingham and Swindon

Mayor's Response:

I know how important it is to improve rail connectivity, and rail plays a vital role in allowing residents to travel across the region and beyond. As well as connecting residents to jobs and opportunity, travelling by rail can also reduce congestion on the roads, reduce pollution, and drive economic growth through connecting key Growth Zones.

The Bristol-Oxford connection is an important one, and I wrote to GWR last August to highlight my support for the Bristol-Oxford trial service and efforts to extend these services to weekdays, and this is also something which I have discussed with the Secretary of State. We are in close contact with GWR, and will engage with the Office of Rail and Road (ORR) as appropriate going forward.

Question 60 – David Redgewell

Will the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset re
Tendered bus service from 26 th July 2026

Or similar routes

40 Avonmouth Dock, Lawrence weston Henbury cribbs causeway bus station.

99 Chew valley local service

X91 Bristol South Bristol Chew valley.

534 Filton to Emerson green East Bristol

2 V odd Down to Timsbury Paulton Midsomer Norton westfield Radstock

K1 Keynsham Town service

P1 Bristol to Winsford.

X10 Bristol Southmead hospital ,cribbs causeway shopping centre bus and coach
station, Portishead Clevedon and Yatton Railway station.

X7 Bristol bus and coach station Harbourside Hotwells.Clevedon dial Hill

50 / merger with Bristol city centre Broadmead shopping centre, St Paul's st werburges
Eastville park station Eastville park Fishponds.

Y8 Yate Park and ride site Yate railway station yate bus station chipping Sodbury

Wickwar Charfield Wotton under Edge new Railway station merger with a service to
Stroud discussion with stagecoach west and Gloucestershire County council.

When will tender or revised Tenders be

Put out for buses to serve these communities.

Mayor's Response:

We are currently reviewing all bus services where the contracts are due to end in July 2026, and we're looking at all of the options to consider how these services can best be delivered for the residents that use them. We anticipate that tenders will be released in the next few weeks following the conclusion of this work.

Question 61 – Christina Biggs

Has WECA discussed our Platform 1 tram-train idea (presented at several previous Joint Committee meetings) with the Temple Quarter project team?

Mayor's Response:

We are working closely with the Bristol Temple Quarter partnership, alongside GWR and other partners, around potential options in line with our Transport Vision, including a dedicated mass transit team for the first time.

As our mass transit plans develop, we will be discussing a range of ideas about the future of our transport network. Our ambitions need to consider existing and planned rail services, and we are working with partners to do so.

Question 62 – Christina Biggs

Q2. Were N Somerset to join WECA, would WECA assist N Somerset with sourcing funding to maintain the Somerset Levels? We note that Network Rail have a duty to contribute to the costs of maintaining their embankments through the Somerset Levels and also that WECA are already assisting with flooding in N Bristol.

Mayor's Response:

It is important to protect and enhance our region's natural landscapes. The Somerset Levels are managed by various public bodies – largely by Somerset Council, the Environment Agency, Internal Drainage Boards, and the landowners

such as Network Rail who hold responsibility for drainage on land, water courses, and highways.

We regularly engage with the Environment Agency on a number of issues, and we would be happy to discuss the Somerset Levels with them as appropriate in the future.

Question 63 – Jackie Head

Please can you detail the cost per passenger for WESTlink in the Chew Valley zone? and the cost per passenger generally across all zones in WECA.

Mayor's Response:

The cost per passenger journey metric for any bus service is not the only measure that is used when assessing performance. We await government guidance on socially necessary bus services, but WESTlink does play a role in ensuring that people have access to a bus service, especially in more rural areas.

For WESTlink overall in January 2026, the cost per passenger journey was almost £24 with variation between zones and routes, with some costing up to around double that.

A new provider has been appointed to deliver the WESTlink South Zones from April. The authority anticipates that here, the delivery model rolled out in other zones should see the overall cost per passenger journey fall and service performance improve.

Question 64 – Jackie Head

Please can the committee advise us of the precise timetable (for decisions being taken and announced) for future public transport in the Chew Valley area after July 2026, so that we can prepare the community for change.

Mayor's Response:

We are fully committed to working with communities throughout this process, in line with procedures set out in legislation and by the traffic commissioner, and we are working collaboratively with a range of partners to do that.

Members of the authority's transport team will be attending a meeting very soon to speak with residents, and we'll continue to engage with communities over the coming weeks and months.

Question 65 – Elaine Workman

Does the Mayor acknowledge that the MCA have been providing The Big Lemon with obsolete Ticketer machines during its tenure of operating the WESTlocal routes, and that this has meant that stats for the 99 route have missed 83% of timing points in January 2026 and 52% in February 2026?

Mayor's Response:

The authority is aware that there have unfortunately been several issues that we understand have impacted ticket machine performance. While we have access to a small supply of ticket machines which can be used where needed, it is the responsibility of bus operators to ensure that ticketing machines are fully operational.

We use a range of different statistics to build an overall picture of bus routes. This includes ticket machine data, but also user and survey data.

Question 66 – Elaine Workman

2. Has this shortfall of data (across the full operation on the 99 and X91 routes) been built in to calculations of cost per passenger for these route

Mayor's Response:

As part of the Grant Agreement, the authority is provided with data, including passenger numbers, to help inform our analysis. Officers use a range of statistics including ticket machine and survey data over a period of time to provide an overall picture of routes.

Question 67 – Phil Collins

Will the MCA replace the Ticketer machines on WESTlocal buses now that you have been informed by Ticketer that the present WECA owned machines are obsolete

Mayor's Response:

The authority provided ticket machines to smaller operators in the region, utilising £250,000 of government funding. These machines are older but, I am advised, remain supported by the supplier. A new generation of machines is now available for operators to consider. At the present time, the authority does not have a specific funding stream for purchasing new machines for bus operators.

Question 68 – Phil Collins

2. Can the Mayor guarantee that this will be organised in time for the start of the change of operator and change of 99 route in April?

Mayor's Response:

The authority's officers are dealing with this operational matter, and I have asked the relevant team to provide you with a fuller response.

Question 69 – Denise Poole

link to airport expansion

Is there an agreed budget?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not

linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

In July, I set out my position in relation to the airport, explaining that new laws tabled in Parliament look set to provide regional mayors with new powers on planning. For our part of the world, that would include North Somerset should they join our combined authority. Mindful of that responsibility, my approach, now and in the future, will be to carefully consider planning applications at the appropriate stage, looking at all the evidence.

Last month, we published our Transport Vision and this sets out our ambitions for a transport network that people can trust. We have a record transport funding settlement of £752 million secured last year from government, and around £150 million is proposed to be allocated to developing mass transit. Council leaders and I have a shared ambition to begin delivering the first mass transit projects within four to five years. We see high-quality mass transit as being an essential ingredient to connecting up our Growth Zones across the region, one of which is the North Somerset Growth Gateway (which includes the airport).

We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 70 – Denise Poole

Have North Somerset agreed to any proposals?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

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Question 71 – Richard Frost

Why not wait until firm mass transit plans are agreed before granting expansion plans.

Mayor's Response:

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project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 72 – Richard Frost

What is the route from Bristol to the Airport going to be ?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 73 – Michael Lee

As the airport is using the above scheme as justification for its expansion plans I would like to ask:

a. Why not wait for the Mass Transport Scheme to be completed before considering the expansion plans.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 74 – Michael Lee

b. How would the scheme be routed bearing in mind that any road works on the A38 causes massive disruption to local communities with almost constant congestion.

As an immediate local to the scheme I believe the expansion will cause more disruption around the area as high parking prices imposed by the airport causes major local upset with the increase in drivers trying to find alternative parking solutions.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 75 – Joanne Dando

I understand that you will be discussing a proposed mass transit scheme for transport to and from the airport on Thursday 27th March and that we are allowed 2 questions each.

My questions, though I have more than 2, are as follows -

What is the proposed route, given that it would presumably have to pass between the reservoirs at Barrow Tanks.

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 76 – Joanne Dando

How is it being funded?

Whatever transit scheme you come up with I'm afraid people will still travel to the airport in their cars.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 77 – Debbie Johnson

Regarding any discussion about transport in WECA.

I would like to state that effective transport infrastructure serving Bristol Airport needs to be put in place as a matter of urgency to alleviate the traffic congestion created by their previous expansions and that no further expansion should be considered until this is done.

Question 1

What are the plans for rapid transport link to Bristol Airport?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 78 – Debbie Johnson

Question 2

Where is the money coming from?

Mayor's Response:

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Question 79 – Sally Lee

I understand that Bristol airport is putting in a planning application to increase passenger numbers by another 3 million.

The mass transport Scheme appears to be part of their reasoning to justify this application.

My first question is...

Why not wait until the Scheme is completed and then consider the airports expansion plans???

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 80 – Sally Lee

How will this be paid for????

The traffic around Bristol airport is presently extremely busy and extremely difficult for local residents.. During times when there are accidents and closures of the M5 motorway it is impossible to drive anywhere around our villages as they are clogged with traffic in all directions.

Please take this into account when deciding the transport network.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 81 – Cery Lawson-Tancred

As emissions from aviation are growing faster than any other mode of transport how does the WECA support of a mass transport link to Bristol Airport meet their stated Paris Agreement net zero objectives when it is being identified as a key element of facilitating the growth of the airport..

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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Question 82 – Cery Lawson-Tancred

As all decisions have consequences could you please give me the criteria by which you carry out a cost benefit analysis on any element of your plan but with specific reference to the expansion of Bristol Airport, being facilitated by your mass transit proposals, that will result in more noise and pollution to a larger geographical area with reduced intervals between planes and larger aircraft.

Mayor's Response:

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Question 83 – Andrew Lynch

At the last question time I asked the following:

Dear Mayor Godwin

As the role of Weca becomes both broader and more complex, could you commit yourself and your chief executive to supplying monthly diaries of meetings, travel and expenses, and gifts and hospitality (which of course you already do), as well as an organisational chart of the senior roles within the authority. This would be an opportunity for the authority to lead on transparency.

None of this has happened. I am afraid your answers provoked many questions and I am only limited to one here, which is:

Please provide to the public as soon as possible all monthly diaries, (directly or indirectly paid) costs of travel, accommodation and gifts/hospitality records for yourself, the chief executive and the deputy mayor from May 1, 2025.

Mayor's Response:

My answer at the last meeting explained that some of this information is already published on the authority's website.

Since then, officers have begun working through the 100 or so entries in my diary for each month since I took office. Following events this week, the authority is reconsidering the security implications of such arrangements, as well as working to understand the approach of and precedent set by other regional mayors.

Question 84 – Andrew Lynch

Last December, a perspicacious citizen suggested to the audit committee that members of the public should be allowed an oral supplementary question at the public forum, mirroring the practice at Bristol city council. Led by the chair, the audit committee agreed and passed a vote in favour of such a practice being adopted in the new constitutional review. The vote was subsequently reported to this committee, who did not demur.

When I followed that up with a question asking the recent scrutiny committee to pass a similar vote to audit, I received this terse response from officers (who were not the subject of my question):

The subject matter of the report before the committee is the terms of reference for the Overview and Scrutiny Committee. The terms of reference define what the committee exists to do, how it should operate, and what authority it has. These do not include the combined authority's arrangements for public engagement. Such arrangements sit outside the terms of reference and are set out in the standing orders contained within the constitution. Standing Orders will be considered as part of the constitutional review in due course.

Officers may not like my questions but if they are going to attempt answers, they should perhaps provide some useful information such as who will be considering the review of standing orders and when.

Furthermore, the officers made no such comments to audit in December when they voted for public supplementary questions. Nor to the chair of audit when he made his report detailing the vote. What took them so long to make things half-clear?

In the light of the fact that even the prime minister is calling for more transparency these days, can I ask you and the leaders of the unitary authorities to support the idea that members of the public will be allowed to ask supplementary questions of this authority?

Mayor's Response:

The combined authority's arrangements for public participation in committee meetings are set out in its standing orders. These standing orders are being considered as part of the review of the constitution, which is the first of its kind since the organisation was established almost ten years ago. Any changes to the constitution and standing orders are a matter for the Committee, at the end of that process.

Question 85 – David Holmes

The proposed expansion of Bristol Airport appears to depend on the development of a mass transit system.

In your published vision for regional transport which shows a proposed schematic route the mode of this system is yet to be decided.

The image in your document shows an electric light rail station at the airport terminal which would be an excellent choice if it could be delivered.

Is this however a realistic possibility given the topography of the route between Bristol and Lulsgate?

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not

linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

Any planning application in North Somerset will be decided by North Somerset Council. I do not currently have a role in determining individual planning applications, but believe that local people's voices need to be heard in those processes.

In July, I set out my position in relation to the airport, explaining that new laws tabled in Parliament look set to provide regional mayors with new powers on planning. For our part of the world, that would include North Somerset should they join our combined authority. Mindful of that responsibility, my approach, now and in the future, will be to carefully consider planning applications at the appropriate stage, looking at all the evidence.

Last month, we published our Transport Vision and this sets out our ambitions for a transport network that people can trust. We have a record transport funding settlement of £752 million secured last year from government, and around £150 million is proposed to be allocated to developing mass transit. Council leaders and I have a shared ambition to begin delivering the first mass transit projects within four to five years. We see high-quality mass transit as being an essential ingredient to connecting up our Growth Zones across the region, one of which is the North Somerset Growth Gateway (which includes the airport).

We know that we need to make a compelling case to government for further investment, and to do this we need to develop a business case for the scheme. The first stage in this process was approved by this committee in 2024 and focused on four key corridors, including one between Bristol city centre and the airport. This corridor does not just serve the airport but could also provide sustainable transport access to key development sites to unlock new housing and jobs, and provide enhanced public transport access to parts of south Bristol that currently have challenges with access to employment and services.

All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 86 – David Holmes

If this is not possible how would an alternative road-based system be able to deliver reliable services given the traffic congestion on the A38 which potential expansion of the airport would increase to unmanageable levels

Mayor's Response:

Given the volume of questions received on this topic, it is unfortunately not possible to respond to each question individually, but - for absolute clarity - mass transit options and my position on any potential expansion of the airport are not linked. It is also worth noting that today's meeting doesn't include any decisions on either Bristol Airport or detailed mass transit proposals.

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All of our local councils, including North Somerset, have been involved in work on mass transit proposals to date and will continue to be involved as we bring the project forward through the next stages of business case development. Public consultation will also take place as the project develops.

Question 87 – Satjen Joshi

Q1) SOUTHVILLE RESIDENTS IN BRISTOL KEEP GETTING TOLD THAT PROPOSED MAJOR ROAD LAYOUT INTERVENTIONS IN SOUTHVILLE HINGE UPON WECA FUNDING RULES WHICH PROHIBIT THE USE OF :

- a) COST EFFECTIVE TRAFFIC CALMING MEASURES (eg Painted White Lines mimicking zebra crossings and Raised Road Sections to curb speed) ,
- b) HIGHWAYS APPROVED TRAFFIC SIGNS (favouring instead, expensive to maintain ANPR cameras/road blocks) .

IS THIS TRUE, AND IF SO, WHAT IS THE REASONING BEHIND INSISTING MORE TAX PAYERS FUNDS GET USED IN MEASURES THAT ARE NOT IMPERATIVE AND GO AGAINST THE GRAIN OF COMMON SENSE?

Mayor's Response:

CRSTS funding rules do not prohibit the use of any specific traffic management measures. Decisions on interventions are made by the relevant highway authority, subject to meeting business case and value for money requirements. Schemes must also comply with national design standards to ensure they are safe, effective and enforceable.

Bristol City Council has consulted on South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods (SBLN) and it is now for them to refine proposals, considering public feedback and data collected, then submit a business case bid to the regional authority for us to assess in detail. At that stage, I will ensure that officers here consider all previous correspondence and public forum submissions as part of the assessment.

In September, at the outset of Bristol's consultation, I emphasised the importance of hearing local people's voices and that feedback will be a key part of how the combined authority assesses this bid. You may have also seen, to that end, that we have commissioned a full independent review of the EBLN from outside the region, covering engagement and consultation to installation and impact – with all the available data.

Question 88 – Satjen Joshi

Q2) WHEN CAN SOUTHVILLE/BS3 RESIDENTS EXPECT A DIRECT BUS SERVICE TO BRISTOL TEMPLE MEADS STATION , BRISTOL ROYAL INFIRMARY AND BRISTOL BUS STATION, AND WOULD THE INTRODUCTION OF SMALLER BUSES (AS WAS THE CASE IN THE PAST) HELP ACHIEVE A PRAGMATIC SOLUTION FOR EARLY IMPLEMENTATION?

Mayor's Response:

Officers are continuing to work with colleagues from Bristol City Council to consider bus service provision in South Bristol.

Bristol City Council has consulted on South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods (SBLN) and it is now for them to refine proposals, considering public feedback and data collected, then submit a business case bid to the regional authority for us to assess in detail. At that stage, I will ensure that officers here consider all previous correspondence and public forum submissions as part of the assessment.

In September, at the outset of Bristol's consultation, I emphasised the importance of hearing local people's voices and that feedback will be a key part of how the combined authority assesses this bid. You may have also seen, to that end, that we have commissioned a full independent review of the EBLN from outside the region, covering engagement and consultation to installation and impact – with all the available data.

Question 89 – Rosa Kell

omerset bus partnership and Somerset catch the bus campaign.

With 10 Bus service contracts due to expire on 26 July 2026

Will the following bus contract be relet

By the West of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council.

From July 2026

P1 Bristol to Winsford

K1 Keynsham Town service.

2v Bath odd Down park and Ride Timbury Paulton, Midsomer Norton westfield Radstock,

Y8 Yate Park and ride site, Yate Railway station yate bus station chipping Sodbury Wickwar Charfield Wotton under Edge, For Stroud Merry Walk bus and coach station, 25,

Bristol city centre to st Paul's st werburges Eastville park Fishponds.

534 Fishponds to to East Bristol

Service 50 in Bristol

Bristol city centre, Broadmead shopping centre Haymarket Eastville Stapleton village to Frenchay or Fishponds

Peak journeys.

40 Avonmouth Dock Lawrence weston Henbury and cribbs causeway bus station.

X10 Southmead hospital bus station Cribbs causeway bus station, Portishead Clevedon and Yatton Railway station

Will theses area Greater Bristol and Bath into Somerset and Gloucestershire have a bus service or Part registered bus service part Demand responsive bus services

Mayor's Response:

We are currently reviewing all bus services where the contracts are due to end in July 2026, and we're looking at all the options to consider how these services can best be delivered. We anticipate that tenders will be released in the next few weeks following the conclusion of this work.

Question 90 – Rosa Kell

What is being made as part of North Somerset council joining the West of England mayoral combined transport Authority for the mayor Helen Goodwin to percept the Taxpayers of the Great Bristol and city Region Banes and South Gloucestershire county council to pay for Public Transport Network services.

Mayor's Response:

The combined authority does not currently have the power to set a precept (which is an extra charge on people's council tax bills), though this may change through the English Devolution and Community Empowerment Bill, that is currently going through Parliament. This new law is set to mean a number of changes to how we

operate as an organisation, and our teams are engaging with government officials to prepare for these.

Question 91 – Helen Hughes

At the October Joint Committee Meeting the same response was printed to a majority of the many questions on liveable neighbourhoods on account of the volume and a lack of time to respond individually. When will the mayor be addressing these urgent individual concerns?

Mayor's Response:

As explained in the responses published for our committee in October 2025, it was not possible to address over 100 different questions on the same topic.

Bristol City Council has consulted on South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods (SBLN) and it is now for them to refine proposals, considering public feedback and data collected, then submit a business case bid to the regional authority for us to assess in detail. At that stage, I will ensure that officers here consider all previous correspondence and public forum submissions as part of the assessment.

In September, at the outset of Bristol's consultation, I emphasised the importance of hearing local people's voices and that feedback will be a key part of how the combined authority assesses this bid. You may have also seen, to that end, that we have commissioned a full independent review of the EBLN from outside the region, covering engagement and consultation to installation and impact – with all the available data.

Question 92 – Helen Hughes

WECA housing and transport policy is addressing a pressure on housing by the creation of many new dense housing projects and 'new towns' Can you supply the modelling (including the source) showing where this pressure is coming from, i.e. which demographic groups are creating the pressure, the numbers and timescale, and why it is occurring?

Mayor's Response:

It's important that housing is built in the right places with reliable transport connections, access to nature, and where communities need it the most.

The housing crisis means 2,000 children in our region are living in temporary accommodation, with Bristol experiencing the third-highest rate of any core city; house prices in Bath have hit twenty-times average earnings; and 35,000 local families waiting for social housing.

The government has set a target for the West of England to deliver 7,750 homes each year, including in North Somerset. The government sets out housing targets for each local authority using its 'standard method'. This uses a formula that takes 0.8% of existing housing stock as a baseline, followed by an adjustment to increase targets in areas with higher price-to-income affordability ratios.

Each local authority holds information at their local level within their emerging Local Plans, and our Spatial Development Strategy (SDS) will look at this to better understand our region's housing needs. We are commissioning evidence for a detailed breakdown of the data, and it will be published as this work develops.

Question 93 – Matt Sanders

QUESTION TITLE:

The Removal of Hyperlinks from Public Forum Statements

— INTRODUCTION

On Friday 20th March, I submitted a **Statement** for Monday's **Overview & Scrutiny Committee**.

This focused on a claim made on the **Bristol City Council website**, relating to the South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhood. My statement therefore contained a **HYPERLINK**, for readers to see the web-page in question, and understand the reason for my statement.

My statement also included hyperlinks to maps and spreadsheets, published on the BCC website, which I then used to prove that the SBLN statement was not true.

However, before publishing the submitted Statements, the Democratic Services team **removed all the hyperlinks from my text.**

This made it difficult for committee members (and other readers) to follow the points that I made, and to check the veracity of my conclusions.

I therefore queried this action, with the Democratic Services officer(s)...

— CORRESPONDENCE

On 20th March, the **Officer wrote:**

“Having been reviewed your statement will be published with the list of statements on the Authority’s website prior to the meeting. However, we are unable to attach hyperlinks, appendices or images to the statements we publish.”

I replied:

*“... So why are you **“unable”** to include hyperlinks?*

*“Contributors to public forum of Bristol Council meetings routinely include links to websites etc, and they are routinely retained in the published papers. Clearly that is possible — the administrators are **“able”** to do it — as the simple act of copy-pasting the text from the authors’ submissions will automatically bring the links with it. That is easy. What is **more** work, is **removing** the hyperlinks.*

*“So you cannot possibly be **“unable”** to attach hyperlinks.*

*“Perhaps there is some **rule** forbidding links, for some reason...? But I cannot see any such rule stated on the WECA website, or in the Constitution. If such a rule exists, then can you please state where it is to be found, and send me the relevant document.*

“... If you cannot quote any rule which forbids hyperlinks, then can you please retain the links in my text. They are all to webpages on the Bristol Council website, which bring clarify to the points that I am making, as well as allowing readers to check the veracity of my statement.

“So there can be no good reason not to include those links.”

The Officer replied:

“We are reviewing the protocols around public engagement at meetings and will make those available when the Constitution review due for ratification at June Committee is made public.”

So, if those new proposals have **not yet been ratified**, then officers should still be following the **EXISTING** rules — which **DO NOT** require the removal of hyperlinks.

The Officer continued:

“In the meantime, we follow an established practice which has been developed following previous incidences of corrupted/broken links or those hi-jacked via malware to other sites.”

But by simply clicking the links in my Statement, officers could easily verify that they are **NOT corrupted or broken**, or hijacked via malware.

Just because that has happened on a few occasions in the past, it does **NOT** mean that **ALL** links **MUST** be redacted in the future. That would be throwing the baby out with the bath-water, for no good reason.

Democratic Services’ actions in this case should be proportionate to the **ACTUAL** situation — and not an over-reaction to **OTHER** circumstances, which do not apply to this case.

The Officer continued:

“We also do not endorse research or data from sources which have not been verified by relevant officers in our own directorates.”

But the links are not to some obscure or dubious location. They are to **the website of Bristol City Council** — WECA's largest partner.

And officers have not been asked to “endorse” anything.

Obviously WECA does not “endorse” the individual (often contradicting) Statements submitted by multiple individuals. So nor would anybody see the hyperlinks in those statements as being “endorsed” by WECA, or the Democratic Services team, or anybody else. They have been included by the Statement’s author, to illustrate the points they are making.

This is supposed to be free speech, so it would be actively dangerous, if links were **ONLY** to be included if they were “*endorsed*” by officers.

Therefore, **ALL** links should be included in the published papers without question, unless there is a legitimate cause for concern — eg being offensive or defamatory, etc...

Plus, of course, the fact remains that — as well as undermining my Statement for no good reason — this action is patently **UNCONSTITUTIONAL**, as the new protocols have **not yet been ratified**.

— THE WRITTEN RULES

I made these points, and (in two emails on 20th March) requested that I be provided with the full set of written rules relating public forum submissions.

Having had no response, on Monday 23rd March I requested these documents for a third time, and an officer sent the **agenda pages** for that day’s meeting, and the **WECA Constitution**.

And, of course, neither document states **ANY** rule requiring the removal of hyperlinks from a Statement.

The Officer wrote:

“The public engagement as it relates to statements is outlined on the agenda pages here

[LINK REMOVED]

“Where the statement element is clearly intended for spoken/verbal presentation of the statement. This protocol has emerged from interpreting the public engagement elements outlined in the Constitution

[LINK REMOVED]

“Which, as we have said, is currently under review.”

But the relevant parts of the agenda pages, are:

“PUBLIC STATEMENTS

“1. Any member of the public may submit a written statement (or petition) to this meeting.

...

“3. Statements must be submitted in writing ...

“4. ... All statements will be sent to committee members in advance of the meeting and published on the Combined Authority website.

*“5. **Please note:** If any member of the public wishes to attend the meeting to orally present their statement, they are asked please to notify the Combined Authority’s Democratic Services team of this at the point when their statement is submitted and by 12noon on the working day before the meeting at the very latest.*

“6. For those presenting their statements at the meeting, up to 3 minutes ‘speaking time’ is permitted for each statement. The total time available for the public session at this meeting is 30 minutes.”

So a Statement is clearly intended for **WRITTEN** presentation, as that is the way that committee members will receive **most** statements.

The opportunity to present them orally is presented in this document as a Brucie-Bonus, and at Monday’s meeting less that a third of the contributors turned up, to do that. And some, like me, had to paraphrase their written statements, to fit within three minutes.

So the meeting’s “statement element” is **NOT** primarily “intended for spoken/verbal presentation”. **Most** statements will **only** be received in written form.

Plus, of course, what does **THIS** have to do with the removal of hyperlinks...?

— SO, TO SUMMARISE:

- Neither the published Constitution, nor the meeting's agenda papers, state that hyperlinks can and/or should be removed by officers.
- A few isolated instances of corrupted/broken links in the past, should not necessitate a blanket ban in the present or future. Each case should be treated on its own merits.
- Bristol City Council routinely includes links in Statements, without any problem at all.
- The fact that *“research or data”* may be *“from sources which have not been verified by relevant officers in our own directorates”* has no bearing on anything. Statements are clearly the Free Speech views of each individual, and no part of their content needs “verification” by officers.
- Some statements, including mine, are all **ABOUT** the claims made on a third-party website — so the removal of a link to that website fundamentally undermines the Statement — and could be interpreted as deliberate sabotage, which would unfortunately undermine WECA's credibility.
- Even if the rules are currently being re-drafted, they have **not yet been ratified** — so **do not yet apply**.

— SO MY QUESTIONS ARE:

Question 1:

Do Democratic Services now accept that there is no constitutional justification for removing the hyperlinks from my Statement (or those of other parties), so they should be retained in the (similar) statement which I submit for the forthcoming Joint Committee...?

Mayor's Response:

This is a matter for Democratic Services and the Monitoring Officer. Your question will therefore be passed to the relevant team for a response.

Question 94 – Matt Sanders

If The Powers-That-Be are currently considering inserting a rule about removing hyperlinks, in the forthcoming Constitution Review, will they now reconsider, in light of my arguments proposed here...?

Mayor's Response:

The combined authority's arrangements for public participation in committee meetings are set out in its standing orders. These standing orders are being considered as part of the review of the constitution, which is the first of its kind since the organisation was established almost ten years ago. Any changes to the constitution and standing orders are a matter for the Committee, at the end of that process.